

3.3 Codecs, Again?

You just read about Codecs in the Digital Audio chapter, but digital video has its very own list of Codecs that help compress videos into manageable sizes.

For those of you who skipped straight to this chapter, the term Codec actually stands for code-decode. A Video Codec is a compression tool that encodes and compresses video data so as to make it more manageable—especially for transfer or broadcast over the Internet. Even for storage, raw (uncompressed) digital video can eat up thousands of mega bytes of your hard disk space.

Codecs step in and code the video data and make it much smaller. However, since these tools (mainly just mathematical algorithms) are used on one computer to encode and compress the file, another computer will need the same tool to decode and decompress the encoded video. This is where Codecs lose in terms of functionality.

Though there are thousands of Codecs available, you will mostly come across only a few. The popularity of these few have ensured that 99 per cent of the video files you find on the Internet have been encoded using one of the Codecs mentioned a little later.

In case you skipped forward here to read about video, please go back and read the Codecs section in the previous chapter on Digital Audio, as Video is made up of both visual and audio components. The audio stream of a video is encoded using an audio Codec, and the video stream using a video Codec. This section only covers video Codecs!

Codecs?

Since all Codecs have one common aim, to reduce file size as much as possible without affecting the quality of a video or audio stream, we will only be looking at the ones that work well here. Also, since the size of a video stream is orders of magnitude larger than its audio stream, compression is even more vital a matter for video Codecs.